

Game Born in Mexican Prisons Brings People Together

On a Sunday afternoon in Mexico City's Roma neighborhood, Rosa María Espinosa joins about 80 men in a park to play poleana. The almost 100-year-old game was created in a Mexican prison and requires luck and thinking skill.

Poleana still carries a stigma connected to its birth as a prison game. However, it is growing popular as people from different backgrounds discover its appeal.

Espinosa says she like the excitement of the game. "But sometimes," she adds, "the dice aren't lucky."

From left, Salvador Espinosa, Rosa Espinosa, Diego Castillo, Erik Cisneros and Ulises Tiscareño share a joke while playing poleana, a board game invented in prison in Mexico City, Sunday, Dec. 8, 2024. (AP Photo/Ginnette Riquelme)

Playing for freedom

Poleana is played with four people and a square wooden box with a sunken center for dice rolling. Each player has four pieces that they race around the box. They use dice combinations and math to govern how to move their pieces strategically. At the same time, they must also try to block moves by their competitors.

The board represents the limits of a prison and getting out of it before others. Winning freedom is the game's goal.

"People used to say, 'these folks know how to play because they've been to prison,'" said the 62-year-old Espinosa. "Thank God I've never been, but I like to play."

That was the first time she had competed against anyone besides her family or friends. She usually plays on Tuesdays and Sundays in the small church in her apartment building.

Ancient roots

Alejandro Olmos studies ancient cultures at the National Anthropology and History School. He has studied and played poleana for years.

He has followed the game's roots to the Indian game chaupar (or pachisi). He found evidence of the connection dating back 1400 years. After British colonization of India, the game spread to Western countries under different names, including Ludo, Aggravation and Parcheesi.

In 1915, the American company Parker Brothers marketed a similar game. Parker Brothers named it "Pollyanna" after a popular 1913 children's book by Eleanor H. Porter.

Sometime around 1940, the game spread to prisons in Mexico City, including Lecumberri. That prison's physical structure is very similar to the design of the game board. So experts say Lecumberri may have been the birthplace of modern poleana and its new set of rules.

Olmos said that in Mexico, "the game reflects the roughness of prison life: mistakes are not pardoned."

Poleana breaks out

Six years ago, Jonathan Rulleri started a family business marketing poleana. His goal was to bring together people from different backgrounds.

One of the early difficulties was establishing common rules for the game, which in Rulleri's words, "has been spreading from below, from prison to the street and from the street into neighborhoods."

Jonathan Rulleri, the founder of Poleanas Canada Frogs, holds up a poleana board to be raffled off before the start of a tournament in Mexico City, Sunday, Nov. 17, 2024. (AP Photo/Ginnette Riquelme)

The 37-year-old man learned to play while serving a sentence in a prison outside Mexico City, the capital. After his release, he struggled to find work.

He and his wife launched a food delivery service. However, the business proved unsuccessful. This led him to accept an offer to make a poleana board for a friend. Then came another offer. Soon he began to post his creations on social media. He said they gave up the food business and started making poleanas instead.

The business, Poleana Cana'da Frogs, has organized 55 poleana tournaments. They are family-friendly, including people of all ages.

"We want to remove the game's stigma ..." Rulleri said.

In the 1980s, the game began to spread beyond the prisons and into Mexico City's neighborhoods. Tepito is one of the neighborhoods where people are almost always playing poleana.

Fernando Rojas is 57 years-old and learned poleana when he was 18. But it was in prison where he really got good at the game.

"It really helps you escape the reality of being a prisoner and that's how it started," Rojas said. "No one can understand what it's like to be a prisoner ... you don't see the end of your sentence. There are people who have to do drugs as their way to escape. Poleana is very important in prison."

Now the game helps Rojas cope with life's difficulties. "We all have problems, in prison and in the street," he said. "So a lot of people come here for a distraction."

While luck plays a part in the game, math understanding is also important.

Dana Lopez, right, paints a board for poleana while her son Kevin plays in their workshop in the State of Mexico, Mexico, Friday, Oct. 25, 2024. (AP Photo/Ginnette Riquelme)

That is why Diego González and Dana López are very happy that their 7-year-old son Kevin is learning to play poleana. He has fun and his math skills are improving.

González also runs a family business making poleana boards. He started the business after serving a three-year sentence 10 years ago. His boards are popular birthday and Christmas gifts. Some are personalized and might include images of loved ones who have died, or playful pictures for players who are children.

Sales of the board game sharply increased during the COVID-19 pandemic. People were stuck at home and found that the game was a good way to pass the time.

Diego Gonzalez, center, holds a pack of game pieces for poleana alongside designer Carolina Duran, left, and Dana Lopez, his partner, with their son Kevin in the State of Mexico, Mexico, Friday, Oct. 25, 2024. (AP Photo/Ginnette Riquelme)

“They realized it’s not a bad game,” González said, “it’s a game of strategy and getting the family together.”

I’m Anna Matteo.

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The Associated Press reported this story. Anna Matteo adapted it for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

stigma - n. ตราบาป, ความรู้สึกในแง่ลบหรือความอับอายที่สังคมหรือกลุ่มคนมีต่อบางสิ่งบางอย่างอย่างไม่เป็นธรรม

dice - n. ลูกเต๋า (ลูกบาศก์ขนาดเล็กที่มีจุด 1 ถึง 6 จุดอยู่แต่ละด้าน)

strategically - adv. อย่างมีกลยุทธ์, โดยใช้แผนการหรือวิธีการที่รอบคอบเพื่อให้บรรลุเป้าหมาย

reflect - v. สะท้อน, แสดงให้เห็นถึง, ทำให้ปรากฏชัด

delivery - n. การจัดส่ง, การขนส่งและส่งมอบบางสิ่งบางอย่างให้กับผู้รับ

tournament - n. การแข่งขัน, ชุดของการแข่งขันหรือการประลองที่ประกอบเป็นหน่วยการแข่งขันเดียว

distraction - n. สิ่งที่ทำให้เสียสมาธิ, สิ่งที่ยเบี่ยงเบนความสนใจจากสิ่งอื่น

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. According to Paragraph 2, where does Rosa María Espinosa regularly participate in poleana games on a Sunday afternoon?

- A) In a Mexican prison
- B) At her apartment building's small church
- C) In Mexico City's Roma neighborhood park
- D) At a specific tournament venue

2. What characteristic of poleana is highlighted in Paragraph 3, despite its growing popularity?

- A) Its requirement for advanced mathematical skills.
- B) Its association with ancient Indian cultures.
- C) The stigma linked to its origin as a prison game.
- D) The difficulty in establishing common rules.

3. In Paragraph 4, Rosa María Espinosa expresses her enjoyment of the game's excitement. What common frustration does she also mention?

- A) The complexity of the strategic moves.
- B) The unluckiness of the dice sometimes.
- C) The challenge of finding enough players.
- D) The game's historical connection to prison.

4. Based on Paragraph 7, what are the typical number of players in poleana, and what two main tools do they use to move their pieces?

- A) Two players; cards and strategy.
- B) Four players; dice combinations and math.
- C) Six players; luck and quick reflexes.
- D) Eight players; logical deduction and opponents' errors.

5. Paragraph 8 explains the symbolism of the poleana board. What does it represent, and what is the overarching objective of the game?

- A) A battleground; achieving victory through cunning.
- B) A community; fostering social interaction.
- C) The limits of a prison; winning freedom.
- D) A journey; reaching a predetermined destination.

6. In Paragraph 9, Rosa María Espinosa clarifies a common belief about poleana players. What is this belief, and what is her personal status regarding it?

- A) Players are usually very skilled; she is not skilled.

- B) Players must have been to prison; she has never been.
- C) Players are often professional gamblers; she only plays for fun.
- D) Players are generally older; she is 62 years old.

7. Where does Rosa María Espinosa *usually* play poleana on Tuesdays and Sundays, as stated in Paragraph 10?

- A) In the Roma neighborhood park.
- B) At her family's house.
- C) In the small church in her apartment building.
- D) At an organized tournament.

8. According to Paragraph 12, what is Alejandro Olmos's academic background and his long-standing involvement with poleana?

- A) He is a game designer; he invented modern poleana.
- B) He studies ancient cultures; he has researched and played poleana for years.
- C) He is a prison historian; he documented poleana's spread.
- D) He is a math professor; he analyzes the game's strategies.

9. Paragraph 13 traces the origins of poleana. What Indian game is identified as its root, and approximately how old is this connection?

- A) Ludo; dating back 500 years.
- B) Aggravation; dating back 800 years.
- C) Chaupar (or pachisi); dating back 1400 years.
- D) Parcheesi; dating back 1915 years.

10. In 1915, as mentioned in Paragraph 14, an American company marketed a game similar to poleana. Which company was it, and what inspired its name?

- A) Milton Bradley; named after a historical figure.
- B) Parker Brothers; named after a popular children's book.
- C) Hasbro; named after its founder.
- D) Ravensburger; named after its place of origin.

11. According to Paragraph 15, when did the game spread to prisons in Mexico City, and which specific prison is considered a possible birthplace for modern poleana due to its architecture?

- A) Around 1915; Santa Martha Acatitla.
- B) Around 1940; Lecumberri.
- C) In the 1980s; Reclusorio Norte.

D) Six years ago; Almoloya de Juárez.

12. In Paragraph 16, Alejandro Olmos suggests that poleana in Mexico reflects a specific characteristic of prison life. What is this characteristic?

- A) The emphasis on teamwork and cooperation.
- B) The importance of luck over strategy.
- C) The strictness where mistakes are not pardoned.
- D) The desire for distraction and entertainment.

13. What was Jonathan Rulleri's main goal when he started his family business to market poleana six years ago, as stated in Paragraph 18?

- A) To create new variations of the game board.
- B) To document the game's historical roots.
- C) To bring together people from diverse backgrounds.
- D) To teach prisoners math skills.

14. According to Paragraph 19, what was one of the initial significant obstacles faced by Jonathan Rulleri's poleana business?

- A) Lack of interest from the general public.
- B) Competition from established board game companies.
- C) Establishing common rules for the game.
- D) Difficulty in sourcing materials for game boards.

15. Paragraph 21 details Jonathan Rulleri's personal history. Where did he learn to play poleana, and what difficulty did he encounter immediately after his release?

- A) In a neighborhood club; he struggled with game design.
- B) While serving a prison sentence; he struggled to find work.
- C) From his family; he struggled to market the game.
- D) At a university; he struggled to fund his education.